A Complete Small Group Study Resource

Philemon 20–25

A Compelling Appendix

The Epistle to Philemon

Small Group Bible Study Series · Philemon · Study 3 of 3

Source: Dr. C Norman Sellers ThD sellersbibleinstitute.com (used by permission)
Editor: The Gospel Vault

① TEXT	② DEVOTIONAL	③ COMMENTARY	④ SELF-STUDY GUIDE
Foundation	Personal prep	Teacher preparation	Group meeting
Everyone	All group members	Teacher / Leader	Small group

⑤ *Application closes each study and draws from all sections above.*

① BIBLICAL TEXT

NKJV · Philemon 20–25

20 *Yes, brother, let me have joy from you in the Lord; refresh my heart in the Lord.*

21 *Having confidence in your obedience, I write to you, knowing that you will do even more than I say.*

22 *But, meanwhile, also prepare a guest room for me, for I trust that through your prayers I shall be granted to you.*

23 *Epaphras, my fellow prisoner in Christ Jesus, greets you,*

24 *as do Mark, Aristarchus, Demas, Luke, my fellow laborers.*

25 *The grace of our Lord Jesus Christ be with your spirit. Amen.*

Scripture taken from the New King James Version®. Copyright © 1982 by Thomas Nelson. Used by permission. All rights reserved.

② DEVOTIONAL

Personal preparation · All group members

> *“Having confidence in your obedience, I write to you, knowing that you will do even more than I say. — Philemon 21”*

“Parting is such sweet sorrow.” Paul says goodbye to Philemon in three words: a personal word, a public word, and a parting word. The personal word is full of confidence: “I know you’re going to do this — and even more than I say.” Go the extra mile. And, by the way, prepare a guest room. People don’t always do what you expect; they do what you inspect.

The public word is a roll call of fellow workers — among them Mark, the young man who once quit in the middle of the work. Paul now calls him “my fellow laborer.” One failure, but look at all the success before and after. Failure is neither fatal nor final.

And the parting word is grace. Without grace we wouldn’t exist for a moment. Saving grace, sharing grace, serving grace — “be with your spirit.”

Reflect

1. Who has put confidence in you that you need to prove right this week?
2. What failure in your past have you treated as fatal or final?
3. Is your giving and serving a chore — or a grace?

Here, there, or in the air — one day, no more parting.

③ COMMENTARY

Teacher preparation resource · Full text organized under outline headings

> **Proposition.** Paul closes his letter with a personal word (provide me relief, prove me right, prepare me a room), a public word (greetings from fellow prisoners and fellow laborers, including Mark, whose failure was neither fatal nor final), and a parting word — the grace of our Lord Jesus Christ, which saves, shares, and serves.

Introduction

It was Shakespeare who said, “Parting is such sweet sorrow” — two things that are just not compatible in your mind: sweet, sorrow. But then, Shakespeare was Shakespeare. More recently someone penned these words: “The saddest words I ever heard are words of parting.” That’s from the song “Remember Me” — you may recall.

That’s what we’re talking about here today. We’re talking about a goodbye — about parting. And Paul has a way of saying it that we need to hear.

I. A Personal Word – vv. 20–22

First of all, he says there’s a personal word, verses 20 to 22 — very personal to Philemon himself.

A. Provide Me Relief – v. 20

And he says, “Provide me relief,” verse 20.

1. Rejoice Me in the Lord – v. 20a

“Yes, brother, let me have joy from you in the Lord;”

Rejoice me in the Lord, in the first part: “Yes, brother, let me have joy from you in the Lord.” Literally he says, “I want to profit from you.” That’s the word: profit. “I want to profit from you.” And Paul’s not saying he wants to get rich off them — which I hear quite often on the TV. He’s not saying, “I want to build a big ranch in Texas,” or, “I want to build a ten-million-dollar ‘Church for All Nations’ in Orlando.” He’s saying, “I want to profit from you in the Lord. I want to receive from you something that helps me in the Lord” — and I take it he means in the Lord’s work, and in his walk with the Lord.

And I find that in that verse two words are emphatic. Now, by emphatic: one is there because it doesn’t need to be — he just threw it in; and one is there by being out of line, out of place in the verse. The two words are these: “I” and “you.” Now, what does that mean? Why? What is Paul implying?

Well, think about this. If I say to you, “I want to get something from you,” what’s that imply? “You’ve been getting stuff from me. Now I want to get something from you.” That’s what he’s saying. “I want to get something from you.” Until now it has been in the reverse order: Philemon has profited from Paul. Apparently Paul led Philemon to the Lord. Isn’t that wonderful? Yes. They have had fellowship over the years — hearing from each other, probably not contacting each other personally, but they knew about each other. They’ve been following each other in the Lord.

And remember the burden of this letter: get the slave and the slave owner back together in fellowship — not just on a physical level, but on a spiritual level. Get the two back. That would make Paul happy. “I want to be profited by you. Now do this — you owe it to me.” I’m sure that’s back in the back of his mind, because of those two things.

Is there some further implication? Maybe. He may be saying, in the back of his mind, “Send Onesimus to me,” but that’s not stated. He just says, “I’d like to.” Last time, he stated it pretty clearly, carefully. But not here — there’s no further word on this matter. We have no further word on the matter. He’s just saying, “I want to profit from you.”

2. Refresh Me in the Lord – v. 20b

“refresh my heart in the Lord.”

Then he’s saying, “Refresh me in the Lord.” That’s the last part of the verse: “Refresh my heart in the Lord.” Again — it’s my heart. “Refresh my heart in the Lord.”

The word “refresh” — we saw recently, in verse 7, that Jesus used it: “Come to Me, all you who labor and are heavy laden, and I will give you rest” (Matthew 11:28–29). That word “rest” is refreshment. And this is the same word. But then he says, “refresh my heart.”

That word “heart” we saw before too. It’s not καρδία. It’s not the thing that pumps blood. It’s the splanchna — σπλάγχνα. Somebody called it the nobler viscera — the kidneys, everything of that kind. “Refresh me — I want to feel it.” You know — when you saw her the first time, or you saw him the first time, and you got kind of sick to your stomach, got pains in your stomach. That’s it. That’s the nobler viscera at work. And he says, “Refresh my splanchna” — where the affections and the sympathy are, the seat of affections and sympathy.

It would refresh Paul to know that Philemon had accepted him — that Philemon was going to do what he asked. Paul had two sons, Philemon and Onesimus. “Oh, the two of them — if I could just see them together, showing love for each other!” Have you ever had a situation, in your experience, where you saw that two of your children were not getting along with each other? Talk about after marriage, really — they don’t get along. When, after they’re married, they just don’t get along — you say, “Get together!” No. It could happen, and they can tear you up — until one day it happens: they get together. Well, that’s what he’s talking about. “I want them to get together and show love for one another.” That’s “provide me with a relief” — that’s what he’s saying.

B. Prove Me Right – v. 21

Now he also says, “Prove me right.” Prove me right — in other words, “I’m asking you to do something; prove to me that you’re going to do it.”

1. Simple Obedience – v. 21a

“Having confidence in your obedience,”

First of all, in the first part of verse 21, he says, “Having confidence in your obedience.” “I believe that you are going to do as I asked.” They had that kind of relationship! You don’t get things done by telling somebody, “Now, I know you’re not going to do this, but I want you to

do it." No: "I know you're going to do it. I have confidence in you." This is the way to lay things out.

I'm going to embarrass somebody here. I have a friend — a very close friend. I watch, in a restaurant, and this person will say, "Would you do so-and-so for me? Thank you very much" — before the person has even moved: "Thank you very much." Why? Because she's saying — oh, I let it out — she's saying, "I have confidence that you're going to do this." So that's what he's saying here: "I have confidence in you that you're going to do what I say."

2. Superlative Obedience – v. 21b

"I write to you, knowing that you will do even more than I say."

And then he goes on in the rest of verse 21. He speaks of a superlative obedience: "I write to you, knowing that you will do even more than I say." Even more. Go the extra mile, if you will.

Jesus taught that, right in Matthew 5, verse 41. He says, "And whoever compels you to go one mile, go with him two." Now, what He's referring to here is that a Roman soldier could come up to you anywhere in Israel, anywhere where they were in charge, and the Roman soldier could say, "Take my pack. You carry my pack for the next mile." And that was a law. You had to do it. So whatever you're doing — stop; take my pack a mile. So you get to the end of the mile, and Jesus said, now, when you get to the end of the mile, don't just throw the pack down. Carry it. Say, "I'll go one more mile." And the Roman soldier would say, "Yeah?" "You know — go one more mile with you." That's what Jesus told them to do. Go one more mile. We talk about it as going the extra mile.

And before that, in verse 39, He had said, "Whoever slaps you on your right cheek, turn the other to him also" — let him slap that too. I don't like that. No — that's doing more than he asked. And Paul says, "I know you're going to do more than I asked." In other words, do more than is asked. It doesn't seem fair, does it? No.

In verse 40 He says — this is talking about Jesus still — "If anyone wants to sue you and take away your tunic, let him have your cloak also." I heard one man one time say, "That is the answer." Jesus said if anybody slaps you, let him slap you again. If you have to go a mile, go another mile. If he takes your tunic — then he says, "Take off your coat and let him have it." Maybe you feel like doing that. What Paul is saying is, "No — I know you're going to do more. I believe that." So he's saying, "Prove me right."

C. Prepare Me a Room – v. 22

Then he's saying, "Prepare me a room."

1. Plan on It – v. 22a

"But, meanwhile, also prepare a guest room for me,"

Plan on it. "Meanwhile," he says, "also prepare a guest room for me." Now, Philemon had a large room — a large house. He had that; remember, the church met there. So he had room for Paul. Most likely Paul had not been there. And Paul is inviting himself: "I'll be there. Prepare the room."

See — Paul's in prison. How's he going to do that? Well, Paul has prospects of getting out soon. If we go on next to Philippians — which we probably will — we'll see that he's expecting to be released. As a matter of fact, he did get released within a few months. And so when he does, then he'll be able to move around. And so he's saying, "Prepare a room for me."

But it seems to me there's something more than that, don't you think? "You two get together. Philemon, accept Onesimus as a brother. And by the way — I'll be there to see if you did it." I think I read that in there. So he's saying, "Plan on it. Plan on my being there."

2. Pray for It – v. 22b

"for I trust that through your prayers I shall be granted to you."

Then he says, "Pray for it": "for I trust that through your prayers I shall be granted to you." So — pray that I get to come to see you. And of course, that prayer is two-pronged: (1) pray that I get out of jail, and (2) pray that I get to come over there. Paul did get released. We'll talk about that in a minute.

Paul would feel welcome. If you go to somebody's house, and they say, "We've been praying for you to come" — would you feel welcome? That's all that's involved, I think. But don't miss the implication: he is saying, "Don't punish Onesimus; accept him as a brother. I'll be there. Pray about that."

Now, Philemon may have been thinking, "How will Paul ever know? Paul's in Rome. He'll never get out of there. They'll kill him, and then it's all over. I can do as I please." See — back to reality. Paul's saying, "Now, I'm going to come and look. Prepare a guest room!" Because people don't always do what you expect; they do what you inspect. And he's going to go inspect it. That's Paul's personal word.

II. A Public Word – vv. 23–24

Then he has a public word. This public word is verses 23 and 24.

A. Greeting from the Man in Prison with Paul – v. 23

"Epaphras, my fellow prisoner in Christ Jesus, greets you,"

It is a greeting from a man in prison with Paul. "Epaphras," he says, "my fellow prisoner in Christ Jesus, greets you." Who is he, Epaphras? Well, we've seen him before. We saw him in Colossians. Paul says Epaphras "is one of you." So we know now that Epaphras was from the Colossian church. And he was called "a bondservant of Christ, always laboring fervently for you in prayers" — that's Colossians. "He has a great zeal for you" — Colossians — "and those who are in Laodicea, and those in Hierapolis." These are cities of the Lycus Valley. All those people — he had a great burden for them.

He may have been pastor of the Colossian church. Perhaps he came to Rome to see Paul — to get some advice from Paul — about the Gnosticism that was creeping into the Colossian church and the churches of Asia Minor. For some reason he was there, meeting with Paul. So that's the man in prison with Paul.

B. Greeting from the Men in Partnership with Paul – v. 24

> *"as do Mark, Aristarchus, Demas, Luke, my fellow laborers."*

Now there's a greeting from the men who were partners with Paul.

1. Marcus – "Mark, my fellow laborer"

Marcus was one. Marcus — "my fellow laborer." We mentioned Mark before, in connection with Barnabas. Remember, he quit in the middle of Paul's first missionary journey. And sometimes that's what people see. That's all that people say about Mark. That's not the whole story. Now you're going to hear the "rest of the story."

Before his defection

We want to know something about him before his defection. What did he do before that? I found a little verse — I love it — in Mark 14:51-52, It's an incident which we might gloss over. It says this:

> *"Now a certain young man followed Him, having a linen cloth thrown around his naked body. And the young men laid hold of him, and he left the linen cloth and fled from them naked."*

Now, that's when the temple soldiers came to get Jesus and crucify Him. Well, this is what Mark records about somebody who did that. Now, who was that? Well, I think that young man was John Mark. Here's my — and others' — scenario about this. Several things follow:

(1) Mark was the son of the owner of the house where they had the Last Supper — where they celebrated the Passover and initiated the Lord's Supper. (2) He learned about Judas' plan. So I think that Jesus and the disciples were having this, but it was at his house; he may have observed what was going on. So he learned about Judas' plan to betray Jesus. (3) Judas left the dinner ahead of everyone. We know that. And he thought that Jesus was still there. (4) But Jesus and His disciples went to the Mount of Olives — remember that — after Judas left, and Judas didn't know. But Mark knew their destination. (5) So after they left, Mark undressed and went to bed. (6) And then Judas told the Jewish leaders to go to that house: "That's where Jesus is. You can take Him right there." (7) And the leaders came with their soldiers, knocked on the door, Mark got up, and they asked where Jesus was, and Mark told them — soldiers and all that, in the middle of the night: "Yeah, I'll tell you." (8) So then he thought, "Wow — they're after Jesus." And so he threw a sheet about him and ran out there to warn Jesus. But he was too late. (9) And a soldier saw him and grabbed the sheet, and he wriggled out of it and ran away naked.

Why do I bring all that up? It took a courageous boy to do that — a young man, actually — to run out there and tell Jesus the soldiers were coming to get Him. So he runs out there, going to tell Jesus — too late. They already have Him. And so he runs away. But that showed courage. That's the Mark we're talking about — that Mark that failed. Well, Mark didn't fail here. He was a good, courageous, dedicated young man.

And then I say, how could anyone else know about this? It's not in any other Gospel. Mark was the only one who knew about this incident. He recorded it in his Gospel. And he doesn't say who it was. He just says a young man did this. Yeah, sure — it was Mark, I think. So

why do I bring it up here? I wanted to show you that Mark was not a coward. This is before his failure.

After his failure

Now, after the failure, even, we find the same apostle Paul saying good things about Mark. Colossians 4:10: “Mark the cousin of Barnabas (about whom you received instructions: if he comes to you, welcome him).” Well — 2 Timothy 4:11: he tells Timothy, “Get Mark and bring him with you, for he is useful to me for ministry.”

So here in Philemon, Paul is calling him “my fellow laborer.” You know what? I think that’s the best — with all the other things, I think that’s the best one. He’s a fellow laborer with Paul — a laborer right along with the apostle Paul. Oh yeah, he failed Paul. He failed the Lord. But now he is a fellow minister with the apostle Paul.

You know something else? Peter — 1 Peter 5:14 — let’s put this in here this morning — Peter calls him “Mark my son.” He’s been there with Peter, working with Peter — probably an amanuensis with him, a secretary. So Mark was with Peter, apparently working with him. And then Mark wrote the Gospel of Mark, of course. And Peter was the eyewitness when he wrote the book of Mark, I take it.

All of that is to say this: one failure — but look at all this success before and after. So failure, then, is neither fatal nor final. That’s Mark.

2. Aristarchus – “Aristarchus, my fellow laborer”

Aristarchus — “Aristarchus, my fellow laborer.” In Colossians 4:10 he says about Aristarchus, “my fellow prisoner.” Acts 19:29: Aristarchus was with Paul during the Ephesian riots. And when they went to get Paul, they didn’t get him; they got Aristarchus instead. And you could say that he took the fall for Paul. He literally took the fall for Paul.

And later in Acts we see him as he traveled with Paul to Rome. He was there — perhaps a prisoner as well. He says in Acts 27:2, “So, entering a ship of Adramyttium, we put to sea, meaning to sail along the coasts of Asia. Aristarchus … was with us.” So Aristarchus was with Paul during the trip, during the shipwreck, all of that. Aristarchus was there. He is a fellow prisoner, and now he is a fellow laborer. Maybe “fellow prisoner” literally as well as figuratively.

3. Demas – “Demas, my fellow laborer”

And one more — no, two more. One is Demas: “Demas, my fellow laborer.” In Colossians we read the same thing about him — “Demas” [Colossians 4:14]. So a good laborer, apparently.

After Paul had written Philippians, the last of the Prison Epistles, he was released from prison — for two years. Two years later he was picked up again and taken to Rome. And when he wrote 2 Timothy, he was near the time of his death as a martyr in Rome. He says, “the time of my departure is at hand” [2 Timothy 4:6]. So when he wrote 2 Timothy, he was near the end. And in chapter 4 he penned these fateful words, and they are: “Demas has forsaken me, having loved this present world” [2 Timothy 4:10].

So — Demas. I hope Demas found it, like Mark did. Maybe he turned around. But here, it's a sad picture. If I put myself in there, I'm going to go to tears. If we put ourselves in that picture, we could be brought to tears for Paul. Paul the apostle is by himself.

4. Lukas – "Luke, my fellow laborer"

Except for one — that's Luke. "Luke, my fellow laborer." We know that Luke was Paul's faithful physician. And we read in 2 Timothy, "Only Luke stood with me" [2 Timothy 4:11]. Wow. All these people — my fellow workers and all of that — only Luke. Luke stood with me. Faithful to the end.

III. A Parting Word – v. 25

> *"The grace of our Lord Jesus Christ be with your spirit. Amen."*

Then he comes to a parting word, a parting word in verse 25: "The grace of our Lord Jesus Christ be with your spirit." A short greeting — but it could not have been more important if it had been a whole book. One little sentence; one little word: grace.

The most important blessing God gives us is grace. Without grace we wouldn't exist for a moment. It's more than just salvation by grace. Every day we need God's grace. We know that God gives us salvation by grace, through faith. But salvation is only the beginning. I'm reminded of more than just salvation by grace. Two other graces come to mind.

A. Sharing Grace – 2 Corinthians 8:1–7

Sharing grace. Dr. Charles Stanley— is doing a whole series, I think about ten sermons, on giving. Permit me the next five minutes. Two graces. One of them is sharing grace, and I want to give you the whole context on this. What I'm going to say here is in 2 Corinthians chapter 8. He says this:

> *"Moreover, brethren, we make known to you the grace of God bestowed on the churches of Macedonia: that in a great trial of affliction the abundance of their joy and their deep poverty abounded in the riches of their liberality. For I bear witness that according to their ability, yes, and beyond their ability, they were freely willing, imploring us with much urgency that we would receive the gift and the fellowship of the ministering to the saints."*

"Please take my money!" That's what they were saying.

> *"And not only as we had hoped, but they first gave themselves to the Lord, and then to us by the will of God. So we urged Titus, that as he had begun, so he would also complete this grace in you as well. But as you abound in everything—in faith, in speech, in knowledge, in all diligence, and in your love for us—see that you abound in this grace also."*

It's not a chore. It's a grace. Now, I know I'm preaching to the choir here. But that's it. It's important that we understand that giving — the grace of giving — is a privilege that the Lord gives us. And we see it as a grace, not a chore — something that we do.

B. Serving Grace – Hebrews 12:28

But then there's also serving grace. You've heard it — it's one of my favorite things to say. Hebrews chapter 12, verse 28:

> *"Therefore, since we are receiving a kingdom which cannot be shaken, let us hold fast to grace, by which we may serve God acceptably with reverence and godly fear."*

Now, that's my translation of that part of that verse. You get all kinds of different translations — "Let us be grateful," whatever, all kinds of things. But to me, "hold fast to grace" is it. What's he saying? He's saying, "Serve God. Hold fast to grace, that you may serve God acceptably." We can't serve God keeping the law. We can't do it. And we can't serve God if we're holding on to the Mosaic Law. That's what the whole book's about. Understand the grace; accept the grace; but also accept that there is a serving grace that goes with it — the giving grace, the serving grace — all there.

C. Grace Be with Your Spirit

So he says, "Grace — this grace — be with your spirit." Again, he's not talking physically. He's talking spiritually. The results — saving, sanctifying, sharing, serving — all of that are the results of this grace in your spirit.

Conclusion

So he had a personal word: the personal word was about me, Paul. The public word was about others. And the parting word was about God — God's grace.

Yep — parting is such sweet sorrow. But one day — no more parting. Like the bald head: his head resembles heaven, for there'll be no parting there. We have friends who are with us often, and before we leave, somebody will start: "See you here …" and then everybody joins in: "… there, or in the air." That's what it's about. We may see you again here. We may see you again there. But we're all going to see you one day in the air, and that's what we look forward to. That's our greeting — which is not sorrow. That is a sweet one. And we'll see it.

Lord, thank You.

④ SELF-STUDY GUIDE

For use during the group meeting · Focused on the commentary text

Greek Word Study

Verse	Greek Word / English	Strong's # / Translit. / Form	Definition & Significance
v.20	**ὀναίμην** *let me have joy / profit*	G3685 *oninēmi* Aor. Mid. Opt. 1st Sg.	STR: to gratify, benefit, profit. MRV: the verb is related to the name Onesimus. Significance: "I want to profit from you … in the Lord" — not getting rich, but joy in the Lord's work.
v.20	**ἐγώ · σου** *I · you*	G1473 / G4771 *egō · sou* Pron. Nom. 1st Sg. · Gen. 2nd Sg.	ATR: the pronouns carry emphasis. Significance: until now Philemon has profited from Paul; now Paul wants to profit from Philemon.
v.20	**ἀνάπαυσον** *refresh*	G373 *anapauō* Aor. Act. Impv. 2nd Sg.	STR: to cause to rest, refresh. Significance: the word of v. 7 and Matt. 11:28 — now Paul asks for it for himself.
v.20	**σπλάγχνα** *heart*	G4698 *splanchna* N-Acc. Pl. Neut.	STR: the inward parts. Significance: not καρδία but the "nobler viscera" — the seat of affections and sympathy.
v.21	**ὑπακοῇ** *obedience*	G5218 *hypakoē* N-Dat. Sg. Fem.	VINE: obedience as the response of one who listens. Significance: "having confidence in your obedience" — simple obedience.
v.21	**ὑπὲρ ἃ λέγω** *even more than I say*	G5228 *hyper* Prep. + Acc.	STR: over, beyond. Significance: superlative obedience — go the extra mile (Matt. 5:39–41).
v.22	**ξενίαν** *guest room*	G3578 *xenia* N-Acc. Sg. Fem.	STR: hospitality, a lodging. Significance: "Plan on it" — people don't always do what you expect; they do what you inspect.
v.22	**χαρισθήσομαι** *I shall be granted*	G5483 *charizomai* Fut. Pass. Ind. 1st Sg.	STR: to grant as a favor. Significance: Paul's release would be God's gracious gift, in answer to their prayers.
v.23	**συναιχμάλωτος** *fellow prisoner*	G4869 *synaichmalōtos* N-Nom. Sg. Masc.	STR: a fellow captive. MRV: literally a fellow prisoner of war. Significance: Epaphras, "one of you" (Col. 4:12), now with Paul in Rome.
v.24	**συνεργοί** *fellow laborers*	G4904 *synergos* Adj.-Nom. Pl. Masc.	STR: co-workers. Significance: Mark, Aristarchus, Demas, Luke — including Mark, whose failure was neither fatal nor final.
v.25	**χάρις** *grace*	G5485 *charis* N-Nom. Sg. Fem.	THAY: unmerited favor and its effects. Significance: the parting word — saving, sharing (2 Cor. 8:1–7), and serving (Heb. 12:28) grace.
v.25	**πνεύματος** *spirit*	G4151 *pneuma* N-Gen. Sg. Neut.	STR: spirit. Significance: "be with your spirit" — not physically, but spiritually.

Cases: Nom. · Gen. · Dat. · Acc. · Voc. | Number: Sg. · Pl. | Gender: Masc. · Fem. · Neut. | Verb Mood: Ind. · Imp. · Subj. · Opt. · Inf. · Ptc. | Tense: Pres. · Imperf. · Fut. · Aor. · Perf. · Plpf. | Voice: Act. · Mid. · Pass. | Person: 1st/2nd/3rd Sg./Pl.

Sources: STR = Strong's · THAY = Thayer's · ATR = A.T. Robertson, Word Pictures · VINE = Vine's · MRV = Vincent's Word Studies · LXX = Septuagint usage. Parsing: Blue Letter Bible.

Study Questions

Part 1 — From the Commentary

Question	Answer
What are the three parts of Paul's closing?	A personal word (vv. 20–22), a public word (vv. 23–24), and a parting word (v. 25).
Which two words are emphatic in v. 20, and why?	"I" and "you" — until now Philemon has profited from Paul; now Paul wants to profit from Philemon in the Lord.
What does "even more than I say" (v. 21) recall?	Jesus' teaching in Matt. 5:39–41 — turn the other cheek, give your cloak too, go the second mile.
Why does Paul ask for a guest room?	He expected release, and he wanted to see the two together. People don't always do what you expect; they do what you inspect.
What does the commentary teach from Mark's story?	Failure is neither fatal nor final — Mark was courageous before his failure and a fellow laborer after it.
What two other graces does the commentary name?	Sharing grace (2 Cor. 8:1–7) and serving grace (Heb. 12:28).

Part 2 — Study Questions

1. **Why does Paul say "I want to profit from you in the Lord" — and what kind of profit is he not after?**

   > *Leader note: Not riches — a ranch or a ten-million-dollar church — but joy in the Lord: to see slave and owner together in fellowship on a spiritual level.*

2. **How does Paul's confidence in Philemon (v. 21) model a way to ask people to do things?**

   > *Leader note: He says, "I know you're going to do it," not "I know you won't." Like saying "Thank you" before someone has moved, confidence lays things out the right way.*

3. **What does the guest room request add to Paul's appeal?**

   > *Leader note: It was a sincere hope of release, and also an implication: "Don't punish Onesimus; accept him as a brother — I'll be there to see."*

4. **How does the commentary use Mark 14:51–52 to tell "the rest of the story" about Mark?**

   > *Leader note: It suggests the young man was Mark, who courageously ran to warn Jesus — showing Mark was not a coward before his failure; afterward Paul calls him useful and a fellow laborer.*

5. **Why does the commentary call grace the most important blessing?**

   > *Leader note: Without grace we wouldn't exist for a moment. Salvation by grace is only the beginning; grace also shares, serves, and sanctifies — "hold fast to grace."*

Part 3 — Passage Summary

Verse(s)	Theme	Key Truth
vv. 20–22	A Personal Word	Provide me relief, prove me right, prepare me a room — rejoice and refresh me in the Lord; you'll do more than I say; plan and pray for my coming.
vv. 23–24	A Public Word	Greetings from Epaphras, Paul's fellow prisoner, and from Mark, Aristarchus, Demas, and Luke, his fellow laborers.
v. 25	A Parting Word	"The grace of our Lord Jesus Christ be with your spirit" — saving, sharing, and serving grace.

⑤ APPLICATION

Closes the study · Personal & corporate

Application 1 — Go the Extra Mile

Philemon 21; Matthew 5:41

Drawn from Commentary I.B (Prove Me Right) and Devotional ②.

Paul is confident that Philemon will do even more than he asks — the second mile, the other cheek, the cloak too. It doesn't seem fair, but it is the way of Jesus.

Reflection: Where is God asking you to do more than is required?

Practical Step: Choose one obligation this week and deliberately go a second mile with it.

Application 2 — Failure Is Neither Fatal nor Final

Philemon 24; 2 Timothy 4:11

Drawn from Commentary II.B.1 (Marcus) and Study Question 4.

Mark quit in the middle of the work, but that was not the whole story. Before, he was courageous; afterward, Paul called him useful for ministry and "my fellow laborer." One failure — look at all the success before and after.

Reflection: Have you written someone off — or yourself — because of one failure?

Practical Step: Speak a word of welcome to someone who has failed, as Paul did for Mark (Col. 4:10).

Application 3 — Stand Like Luke

2 Timothy 4:10–11

Drawn from Commentary II.B.3–4 (Demas and Luke).

Demas forsook Paul, having loved this present world. Only Luke was with him — faithful to the end. If we put ourselves in that picture, we could be brought to tears for Paul.

Reflection: Who in your life needs someone to stay with them now?

Practical Step: Visit, call, or write to one believer who is going through a lonely season.

Application 4 — Hold Fast to Grace

Hebrews 12:28; 2 Corinthians 8:1–7

Drawn from Commentary III (A Parting Word) and Greek Word Study (χάρις).

Giving is not a chore; it is a grace. Serving God acceptably comes not by keeping the law but by holding fast to grace. Grace saves, sanctifies, shares, and serves.

Reflection: Is your giving and serving driven by duty or by grace?

Practical Step: Before you give or serve this week, thank God for His grace first, and then give or serve as a privilege.

End of Study · Philemon 20–25